Where Do the Stories Happen in America?

Daocheng Lin
Apr. 6, 2026

Abstract: Movies, novels, or games often select a real location as their stage if they don't choose to use a fictional one. Screen tourism has also been many people's favorite motivation to visit somewhere. This project presents data storytelling that consists of dashboards, interactive maps, and an introduction, showing the locations in the United States mentioned in fictional movies and novels, based on datasets from "IMDb Top 250 movies" and "The New York Times Best Sellers." This project both demonstrates how fictional narratives can co-shape the meaning of a place through data points and provides a practical guide for audiences who plan their travels based on fictional experience.

Overview

Fictional narratives shape people's experience of a space by influencing their worldview (Foss, 2017). In Tuan's (Tuan, 1977) analysis of mythical space, the narratives in lore across different cultures construct the meanings of spatial features like directions and cardinal points in different ways. In commercial practice, fictional narratives also have a positive impact on the tourism economy. For instance, The Hobbit Trilogy, which was filmed in New Zealand (Figure 1), had a significant positive impact on New Zealand's tourism and economy: it increased international arrivals by 214,811 and created an additional US$771.80 million in international tourist receipts to New Zealand between 2013 and 2014 (Li et al., 2017). Data storytelling with dashboards, interactive maps, and introductions to locations in fictional narratives of movies and novels in the United States, then, helps travelers plan their itineraries and stakeholders develop their strategies.

Figure 1. The Filming Location of The Hobbit Trilogy in New Zealand. Source: Where Was The Hobbit Filmed? Locations Guide, https://discover.hubpages.com/entertainment/Where-Was-The-Hobbit-Filmed-Locations-Guide

This project aims to create a data storytelling that displays the locations of films and fictional novels in America. To show the intersection between the film's fictional stories and the actual location, I create data storytelling with an interactive map as the main component that illustrates the relationship between the real and fictional places. The interactive map collects data from ranking lists, such as "IMDb Top 250 movies" and "The New York Times Best Sellers." The data storytelling consists of two dashboards:

the locations from fictional novels and the filming locations of movies. Several parameters will be available: The date, the genre, the rating, and typical reviews. In the tooltips, the covers of movies or books will appear, with an introduction available upon clicking. Users can also select the "map view," which shows interactive maps, and the "gallery view," which shows the films and books gallery.

The storytelling of this project considers textual introduction, user interface design, and the overall visual styles. The textual introduction, shown at the beginning of the project, provides an overarching overview and details based on the data points. The user interface will be based on scrolling motion techniques, which are widely used in contemporary data storytelling. The project's visual style will be carefully designed to balance the different tones of movies and novels. For instance, while Goodreads and the New York Times' best-seller lists prefer serif fonts, IMDb uses a sans-serif font as its main typeface. I will use moodboard for my design and inspiration process.

To sum up, the audience will be able to gain the following experiences: 1. They should be able to find insight or surprise from the map. For instance, they might be able to see what the road trip looks like on the map while reading *Blue Highways.* 2. They might be able to attach meaning to their hometown if the film location happens to be their hometown. 3. The audience should discover some new novels and movies, and places that are worth visiting.

Technology
- Tableau: Use Tableau as the main tool to clean the data and create the dashboards.
- Python: Will be mainly used to crawl and clean the data.
- HTML/JS/CSS: Will be further used to fine-tune the dashboards, for instance, to create the sidebar after clicking the covers.
- SQL: Potentially, hosting the data with SQL might be needed.
- Claude Cowork: I might use AI to identify the locations in the movies and the books. If possible, I will also try to use it to mark the route in the road trip novels.

Data
- IMDb Top 250 movies
- The New York Times Best Sellers
- Wikipedia

Process
- Step 1. Screen the books and movies for stories set in America and make a CSV file.
- Step 2. Create a corpus from the entries in Step 1. This corpus will also include the Wikipedia introduction.
- Step 3. Create metadata, including date, locations, and genres.
- Step 4. Import the data into Tableau and make the dashboards.
- Step 5. Further modify the dashboard on the webpage.

Inspiration
- Nobels, no degrees: https://www.informationisbeautifulawards.com/showcase/204-nobels-no-degrees

- The Stories Behind a Line: https://www.informationisbeautifulawards.com/showcase/2497-the-stories-behind-a-line
- Is the Love Songs Dying? https://pudding.cool/2024/11/love-songs/

Potential Challenges:
- Identifying the locations in large texts could be challenging.
- Embedding the whole dashboard on the webpage will be challenging at this level.

Timeline for completion
- Apr. 2026: Finish the metadata creation
- May. 2026: Finish the map-making and finalize it.

AI usage statement
While I didn't use AI to write this proposal, I plan to use it to assist with data collection and data cleaning. While identifying locations in books or movies is very laborious, using AI for these tasks could be beneficial given its ability to cope with large amounts of data.

Reference

Foss, S. K. (2017). *Rhetorical Criticism: Exploration and Practice, Fifth Edition*. Waveland Press.

Li, S., Li, H., Song, H., Lundberg, C., & Shen, S. (2017). The economic impact of on-screen tourism: The case of The Lord of the Rings and the Hobbit. *Tourism Management*, *60*, 177–187. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tourman.2016.11.023

Tuan, Y.-F. (1977). *Space and Place: The Perspective of Experience*. U of Minnesota Press.